critical for supporting local political processes that involved talking with Afghan tribal leaders who knew the Taliban elements. While such engagement with the moderate Taliban was acceptable for tactical reasons, 'any agreement with the tribes would provide temporary relief, at best' India argued. Speaking to Taliban hardliners also sent a 'wrong message to these leaders about their status and ability to influence the situation in Afghanistan'. None of this meant, however, that India would give up on talks with Pakistan, whom New Delhi held responsible for the Taliban's resurgence. Guided by Manmohan Singh's conciliatory approach, India went ahead with the India-Pakistan Joint Counterterrorism Mechanism, whose first meeting occurred on 6 March 2007, four days after the India-US CT JWG meeting (where India would present evidence about the July 2006 Mumbai blasts to Pakistan).[47] Interestingly, in 2007 the US did not share India's pessimism on Afghanistan's security situation, the adverse impact of an intensely corrupt Afghan government, and the futility of talking to the Taliban, or Pakistan's CT collaboration with the US. Narayanan delivered a similar message to US senators John Kerry, Joe Biden, and Chuck Hagel in February 2008, calling an early US withdrawal and talking to the Taliban 'disasterous' for the region.[48] In a couple of years though, the US approach in Afghanistan changed considerably.

On 1 December 2009, in a historic speech from the US Military Academy at West Point after months of intense internal policy debate,[49] US President Barack Obama officially announced that after an initial surge of 30,000 troops, US soldiers will start 'coming home' after 18 months.[50] The focus would be on unified training of the Afghan army and the Afghan police. Though 'fully backed' by Narayanan, the US decision to train Afghans was too late and too little.[51] For serious COIN the US required close to 450,000 soldiers as against the maximum of 142,000 in 2009 after the surge.[52] The troop surge was not meant to counter the Taliban effectively, but to pave the way for a honourable exit—which, in turn, required Pakistan's cooperation. Obama's rise to power in January 2009 had already set alarm bells ringing in New Delhi as Indian officials started thinking that Washington would intervene on Kashmir in order to seek Pakistan's help in Afghanistan. Holbrooke's initial appointment as US special representative to 'Afghanistan, Pakistan, and Kashmir' confirmed these fears (leading to proactive